

Thompson helps Brandon with Race Relations

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By Catherine Watter

Thompson citizen Sukh Khokhar received a lot of media attention when she visited Brandon two weeks ago to give presentations on race relations. Among the media covering her three-day visit were the Winnipeg Free Press, the Brandon Sun and the local television station.

Khokhar was invited by the West-Man Multi-Cultural Council in Brandon to speak to student assemblies, members of the RCMP and police, as well as representatives of Brandon City Council, the Chamber of Commerce and the Brandon Regional Health Authority.

The West-man Multi-Cultural Council and the City of Brandon want to set up a Race Relations Committee similar to the one Khokhar initiated in Thompson eight years ago.

Khokhar's passion to facilitate racial harmony has led her to work with several groups in Thompson. She has helped the Mystery Lake School Division form a policy on racial incidents, the RCMP to develop more culturally sensitive policing policies and practices, helped schools form a model for multicultural education, and is an active leader of the Thompson Multi-Cultural Centre. She is the author of a publication called "The changing face of the Royal Canadian Mounted Police" organizes confer-



Mrs. Sukh Khokhar stands in front of the 'mission statement' of the Thompson Multi-Culture Centre. She has been invited to be a Race Relations consultant for the City of Brandon, which is looking at forming its own Race Relations Committee.

on what a Racial Relations Committee can do for their City.

"Everyone is very conscious of needing to bridge gaps between different groups," Khokhar says of the people in Brandon. "The issues of racism and discrimination are very much on the minds of people."

She says it is important to create a common ground, a forum, where different groups can meet and work together on addressing the issues surrounding prejudice, discrimination and racism.

Some issues that were discussed during her visit were the isolation between the different groups, a lack of minorities in the work place and the fact that they didn't have a common platform

solutions to their problems in a positive manner.

Khokhar says she spoke to very supportive of forming a committee on a city wide level, and they expressed deep concern about the problems of racism.

She tried to contact the Aboriginal friendship centres and the Objibiway police while she was there, but couldn't get appointments set up.

"It was very important to me that we meet," she says, and explained that the West-Man Multi-Cultural Council will continue trying to get hold of them and invite them to the community consultation session which will be held to discuss the need of establishing a Racial Relation Committee in

sive to have done so much in the area of promoting racial harmony, and many were enthusiastic. Brandon Mayor Reg Atkinson told her City Council was eager to hold its own brainstorming session before the community consultation, and others told her they wanted to bridge the gap between minorities and non-minorities, establish a more open work force, promote community-based policing, and to have a council where some race relations complaints can be addressed in a positive manner instead of becoming a police issue.

While Brandon is free to use Thompson's Race Relations Committee as a model, they are also free to make whatever modifi-